that had dwindled over the past nine years. The resounding sentiment was that ‘he is secular, a 100 per cent’.

When women rallied around Rahul Gandhi, their confidence and trust were palpable. They would reach out to touch him and offer warm hugs, and in return, he reciprocated with equal warmth. These interactions were devoid of any theatrical grandeur—they were authentic and unscripted. People recognized this sincerity, which was unannounced but deeply felt. It moved them profoundly.

The substantial presence of women, youth, particularly young girls, and a massive turnout of Muslims, including numerous women from their families, all conveyed a singular message. Here was someone who offered them hope and could be trusted. The prevailing insecurity in the nation, particularly among minorities and marginalized communities, could only be addressed through a sweeping movement rooted in love and a resounding message to resist fascism. The Bharat Jodo Yatra featured many slogans, on love and against hate, on price and inflation, on unemployment and on protecting the Constitution. But BJY was itself the embodiment of the message—a beginning and a means to reclaim the unity and diversity that define the essence of India.

Rahul Gandhi’s journey across the country resonated with the spirit of Mahatma Gandhi, who undertook several iconic walks as a symbol of resistance, change and unity. Rahul’s Yatra stood as a modern-day echo of the Mahatma’s timeless principles, emphasizing the power of unity and the enduring relevance of love and non-violence.

## The Wake-Up Call: The Congress Revived by the Bharat Jodo Yatra

Amid a demoralized Congress, the Bharat Jodo Yatra emerged as a resounding wake-up call. It came as a lifeline to a party grappling with electoral setbacks and a dwindling morale, especially in the state of Kerala, which had witnessed two consecutive losses in state elections.